

Govt. Graduate College for Women, Baghbanpura, Lahore
BS English 3rd semester

Topic 3

Epistemology

Short Questions.

1. Define epistemology.

Ans. Epistemology is a branch of philosophy that deals with questions about knowledge. What is knowledge? How knowledge is acquired? Can knowledge be certain? Do we really know about things? Etc. These are all questions related to epistemology.

2. What are the major school of thought in Epistemology?

Ans. Although epistemology has many branches however the major schools of thought in epistemology are two namely Rationalism and Empiricism. Rationalism favors reason as a source of valid knowledge while according to empiricism all knowledge is sense perception.

3. What is meant by genuine knowledge?

Ans. according to Rationalists knowledge is genuine when it is acquired through intellect and logic. It is based on facts that are not grounded in experience rather is self evident.

4. How is intuition a source of knowledge?

Ans. Intuition is considered as a real, distinct and clear source of knowledge. It is a personal and private experience and therefore cannot be conveyed to others. Because of being personal in nature intuition is not considered a valid source of knowledge by many philosophers.

5. Can revelation be considered as a source of knowledge?

Ans. Revelation is a source of knowledge where God through His messengers reveals knowledge to the mankind. This knowledge is infallible and the experience is of extreme private nature. Because of its private nature like intuition, revelation is also not considered as a reliable source of knowledge.

6. What is the role of authority in epistemology?

Ans. Experience and observation are usually used to gather information however sometimes direct observation or experience because of the

nature of the subject matter. For example noting an event that has happened many years ago or has happened in an other country or continent; we can't make a direct observation. Therefore we need to rely on authority. Books, news channels, magazines, experts of a certain field etc are all examples of authority.

7. Define rationalism.

Ans. Rationalism as a theory of knowledge claims that all genuine knowledge is possible through reason alone. The criterion for truth is not sensory but intellectual and deductive. The most prominent rationalists are Rene Descartes, Spinoza and Hegel.

8. Define empiricism.

Ans. the theory that all knowledge is based on experience derived from the senses. Stimulated by the rise of experimental science, it developed in the 17th and 18th centuries, expounded in particular by John Locke, George Berkeley, and David Hume.

9. What is a priori knowledge?

Ans. A priori knowledge is the kind of knowledge attained through reasoning prior to experience. These statements are self evident and considered truth. For example $1+1=2$ is an a priori proposition because we can know this to be true by just thinking.

10. What are innate ideas?

Ans. Innate idea is a concept introduced into rationalism by Rene Descartes. These ideas are certain in nature and cannot be falsified. These ideas are allegedly inborn in the human mind. These innate ideas are same for everyone everywhere. Language, logic, ethics, metaphysics and math are a few examples of innate ideas.

11. What is deductive method?

Ans. Deductive reasoning is a logical approach where we progress from general ideas to specific conclusions. This method was devised by Rene Descartes and is the way knowledge is acquired in rationalism. We take general certainties and derive singular conclusion from it. For example

All men are mortal

Socrates is a man

Therefore Socrates is mortal

12. "I think therefore I am". explain this quote in terms of rationalism.

Ans. I think therefore I am is a teaching present at the heart of rationalism. The statement was given by Descartes who believed that at the base of all knowledge is reason and all doubts are eliminated by reason as well. "I think; therefore I am" was the end of the search Descartes conducted for a statement that could not be doubted. He found that he could not doubt that he himself existed, as he was the one doing the doubting in the first place.

13. Name the books written by Rene Descartes.

Ans. The books about rationalism written by Rene Descartes are "A Discourse on Method" and "Meditations".

14. Name the book written by John Locke.

Ans. A very famous book written by John Locke that consists of his epistemological beliefs is "An Essay Concerning Human Understanding".

15. What types of experience are described by Locke?

Ans. According to Locke there are two kind of experiences as follows:

1. Observation of external objects which he refers to as sensations
2. Observation of internal operations of the mind. Locke used the term reflection for these kind of experiences. Examples are thinking, doubting, willing etc

16. What is meant by Tabula Rasa?

Ans. Tabula Rasa, in epistemology is a supposed condition that empiricists have attributed to the human mind before ideas have been imprinted on it by the reaction of the senses to the external world of objects. At birth human mind is like a clean slate and as his exposure to the external world increases concepts are created in the mind.

17. What is the distinction between simple and compound ideas?

Ans. Locke while explaining his empirical ideas made a distinction between simple and compound ideas regarding knowledge. A simple idea is anything which is an immediate object of perception meaning sensation or anything that the mind perceives itself through reflection.

Compound ideas are created when simple ideas are combined for example a compound idea of apple is produced by bringing together simple ideas of certain colors, texture and taste etc.

18. What are primary qualities?

Ans. Primary qualities according to Locke are qualities of an object as they appear in our mind. These are the qualities that are the first set of qualities observed in any object as it is being perceived. In other words the qualities resemble the ideas they cause in a mind. Examples of primary qualities are solidity, motion, number, figure etc.

19. What are secondary qualities?

Ans. Secondary qualities according to Locke are arrangements or coming together of primary qualities that cause sensible ideas in the brain such as sound, color, taste etc.

20. What is intuitive knowledge?

Ans. Intuitive knowledge can be considered as non-consciously recalled information, such as implicit memory or procedural memory, both of which are forms of knowing that are not necessarily accompanied by verbal awareness of knowing. Its example can be a skill learned such as race car driving where a driver can intuitively use maneuvers to better perform in a race.

21. What is demonstrative knowledge?

Ans. Demonstrative knowledge is the kind of knowledge where the mind perceives the agreement or disagreement between ideas but not immediately. For example in some inferences in logic the connection between premise and conclusion is mediated by another premise. For example the connection between "All men are mortal" and "therefore Socrates is mortal" can be reached only with the help of a mediate premise "Socrates is mortal".

22. How did David Hume rejected the idea of Law of Causation?

Ans. David Hume is most famous for his criticism of law of causation. Law of causation is considered as a fundamental law in making laws specially in science where we believe that every event is a cause of an other event and this sequence has continued from the beginning of universe and will go on till the end. In reality there is no logical necessity in the fact that the cause will always precede the effect rather we are only accustomed to seeing things and patterns in this way.

23. "It is wrong to make predictions about future based on past experience." explain.

Ans. According to Hume making predictions about future based on past experiences is a flaw of epistemology. He believed that it is wrong to make such prediction because there is no justification in this assumption that future will resemble the past. For Hume while making such predictions we are operating as creatures of habit rather than rational beings.

24. What are moral views of David Hume?

Ans. As far as morality is concerned Hume rejected the view that God plays an important role in creation and reinforcement of moral values. In response he presented the first ever purely secular moral theory based on the principle of utility.

25. How did Hume escape extreme scepticism?

Ans. Through his reasoning Hume had reached a conclusion that even our best theories about the world will have contradictions. Therefore he believed that no durable good could ever result from extreme scepticism. Instead he believed that one should be modest and cautious while making efforts in understanding the world around us.